Martin, Ian Austin. Seeing them in person makes them real – them playing under a darkened Mancunian sky making them seem at once mercurial and everyday. I travel to see them in the final at Lord's too, with my dad and my mum's brother, Mark. It's the first time I've seen Lord's, bending my head to make sense of the slope, awed at the magnitude of it all. Lancashire win, despite an Aravinda de Silva hundred, and I watch everyone who has made the same car trips down with their families run across the ground, filling the regal space with joy as the Lancs players wave from the dressing room, drinks aloft.

Gaz and I get jobs at Burnley Football Club in the summer of 2000, the year they sign Ian Wright. We work at the ticket office and they send Ian around. It is the first time I have met an actual sporting hero and I shake his hand for slightly too long as he does the rounds with the staff. It is quite a special experience, but not special enough to install sufficient respect for Gaz and I to think twice about playing headers and volleys on the pitch at half-time in front of the cricket field stand. We are very quickly escorted off by the general manager, Andrew Watson, and told our time with the football club has come to an end.

As our clothes get trendier (I find myself becoming particularly besotted with the play on words French Connection has conjured up with FCUK IT), the three of us bundle into many unsuccessful, awkward and left-field dating escapades. I regularly find myself feeling incredibly out of my depth on these, and often come up with quite ill-thought-out ways to bail. I leave a message on a pizza box for one girl when she left for a minute, writing that I'd had a 'family emergency', and 'apologies for the impromptu departure' on top of it. Another time, I leave via the back door of the Manor Barn pub when I realise that we are on dates with women over twice our age.

We spend that off season playing pool at Rileys, Gaz skipping work so that he can meet me for sausage and chips. We do strange, sporty things for teenagers to do, like play squash. We stay at a girl's house while telling our parents that we are staying at each other's. It's a weeks-long, pre-arranged, meticulously planned ruse, only for me to accidentally order a takeaway back to my own house and blow the whole thing open. I split my head open on a drainpipe outside Gaz's house, pretending to head-butt it and kicking it with my foot to make the sound, only to actually head-butt it. His mum has